

Microsoft Advertising Partner Pulse

February 18, 2026

 Microsoft Advertising



CODE OF CONDUCT

Microsoft's mission is to empower every person and every organization on the planet to achieve more. This includes all Microsoft events and gatherings, including on digital platforms and in person, where we seek to create a respectful, friendly, enjoyable, and inclusive experience for all participants.

We expect all event participants to uphold the principles of this Code of Conduct. The Code of Conduct applies to all aspects of the main event and any related activities, whether digital or in person. Microsoft does not tolerate the following in any aspect of the event program, including business and social activities:

Behavior that is disruptive, disrespectful, or degrading to others, including any messages, images, or interactions by anyone, in any form, regardless of location.

Harassment or discrimination based on age, ancestry, color, gender identity or expression, national origin, physical or mental disability, religion, sexual orientation, or any other characteristic protected by applicable local laws, regulations, and ordinances.

We encourage everyone to assist in creating a welcoming and safe environment. Please report any concerns, harassing behavior, or suspicious or disruptive activity to venue staff, the event host or owner, or the nearest event staff.

We also encourage everyone to contact Microsoft's Business Conduct Hotline at any time if you feel anything or anyone is not following this Code of Conduct or is inconsistent with Microsoft's culture. The Hotline is available regardless of whether you are a Microsoft employee and can be reached at buscond@microsoft.com or +1 (877) 320-MSFT, or call collect outside the United States at +1 (720)-904-6844. Microsoft employees can also report any concerns to their Microsoft Manager.

Microsoft reserves the right to refuse admittance to or remove any person from a Microsoft event at any time at its sole discretion.

Let's get connected

01

Ask a question

Type in the Q&A window if you have questions.

02

Engage with our speakers

Use reactions to engage with speakers. These can be found in the tool bar at the top of your screen.

03

Turn on live captions

If you find this useful you can turn on live captions by clicking the CC button at the top of your screen.

04

Please note

By joining this event your personal information such as name, email and phone number, may be visible to other participants.

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Partner Program Updates

Chinmayi Bhavanishankar



New year, new look

Earning a 2026 Partner Badge showcases our partner's dedication to excellence and continuous growth in the ever-evolving digital advertising landscape.

To download your new Partner Badge login to the [Microsoft Advertising Partner Program Website](#).



ONE-TIME REAUTHENTICATION

A one-time reauthentication is required of all existing partner portal users as part of a security update, so please go through steps as directed on the portal.

LOGIN ISSUES

If you have trouble logging in, please reach out to [support](#) or post in the Partner Community on LinkedIn.

Get recognized! Tell us your story

The **Microsoft Advertising Partner Celebration** highlights the exceptional and innovative work of our partners.

Award winners will feature in a blog post, be recognized on our social platforms, and be eligible for the **Global Emerging Partner of the Year** award at Microsoft Advertising Activate 2026.



Partner Growth Award

Awarded to the Partner that shows the most growth through revenue, new accounts, new industry verticals, and certifications in the previous 6-12 months.



Product & Innovation award

Awarded to the Partner who adopted a new feature or innovative strategy that delivered outstanding outcomes and value for their clients.



Open Mar – Apr 2026

Available for partners enrolled in the Partner tier of the Microsoft Advertising Partner program only.

Partner Program Engagement Timeline

Coming up in the next few months

Partner Pulse February

Football insights, Brand Agent
Today!

Microsoft Advertising Activate

May 20, 2026

Partner Pulse August

TBD

Partner Workshop March

Brand new training
March 4, 2026

Partner Celebration

Partner tier awards
March – April, 2026

Partner Workshop June

TBD

Partner Sweepstakes

Sept – October 2026

New Ways to Excel with Performance Max

Explore the updated learning experience: a new path, refreshed courses, and an all-new badge.

Get started now on [Learning Lab](#).



AT A GLANCE

Performance Max learning path

- Introducing Microsoft Advertising Performance Max
- Creating Microsoft Advertising Performance Max campaigns
- Implementing and Optimizing Microsoft Advertising Performance Max
→ Earn the Performance Max Badge!

SPECIALIZED LEARNING PATH

Introducing a brand-new **Performance Max learning path** dedicated entirely to Performance Max, giving you a clearer, more structured way to build your skills.

NEW PMAX COURSE

A key highlight of this rollout is the new **Implementing and Optimizing Microsoft Advertising Performance Max** course, which offers an interactive, scenario-based learning experience.

REVISED CONTENT

We've strengthened our **foundational PMax courses** with updated content, improved explanations, and aligned with product updates.

EARN THE NEW PMAX BADGE

Complete the new course to unlock your exclusive **Performance Max badge**. There are no prerequisites required. The badge never expires and can be shared on LinkedIn to highlight your expertise.



Summer of Football:

Fan Engagement & Travel Spending
Trends

Kelli Kemery

Objective:

Understand how fans plan to engage with the summer's largest football championship across travel and retail verticals.

Approach:

- 15-minute online study
- Fielded Dec 2025-Jan 2026
- Audience includes consumers 18-65 in the US/ UK who plan to follow the tournament and are either:
 - Traveling to US, Canada, or Mexico during the tournament and plan to engage in the tournament in or
 - Planning to make retail purchases in anticipation of the tournament

Audience:

- US: 1,046 respondents
 - 626 US Travelers
- UK: 511 respondents
 - 234 UK Travelers

Fans will engage in a variety of ways...



~50%

Plan to attend a Live Match



~75%

Will watch at pubs or fan zones

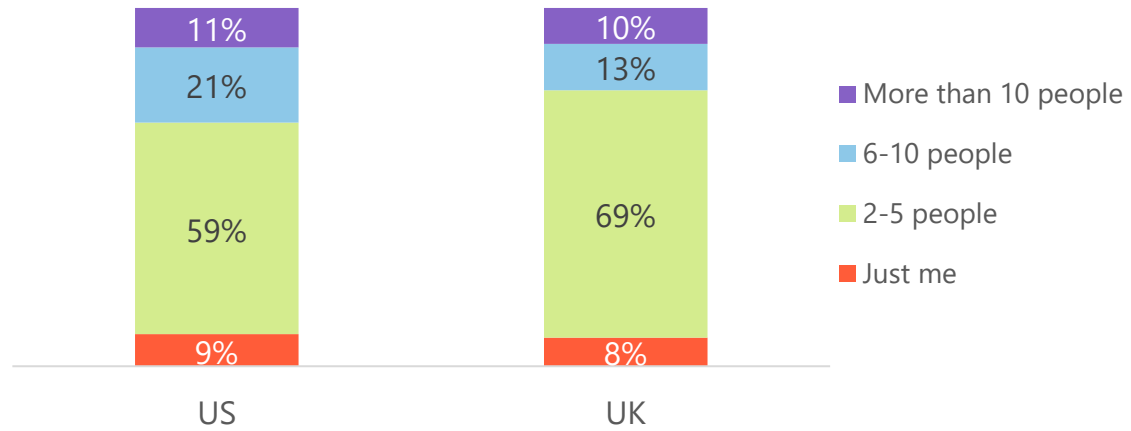


~90%

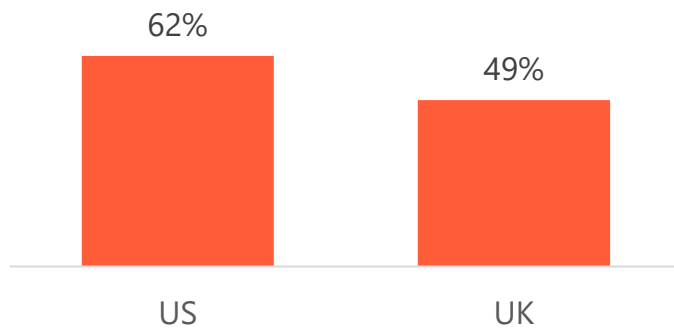
Will watch at home

WATCH PARTIES

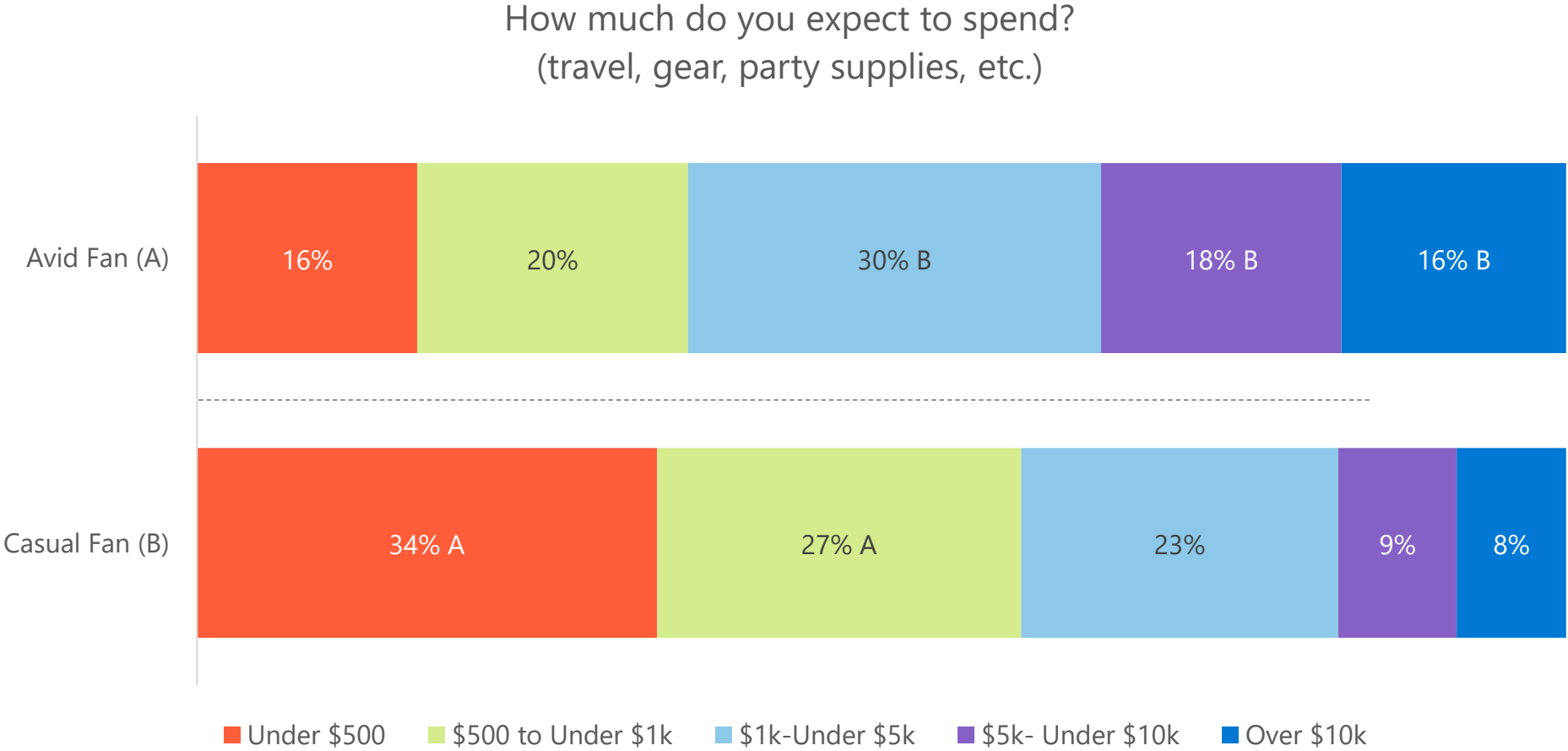
Size of Watch Group



Plan to host 1+ watch parties

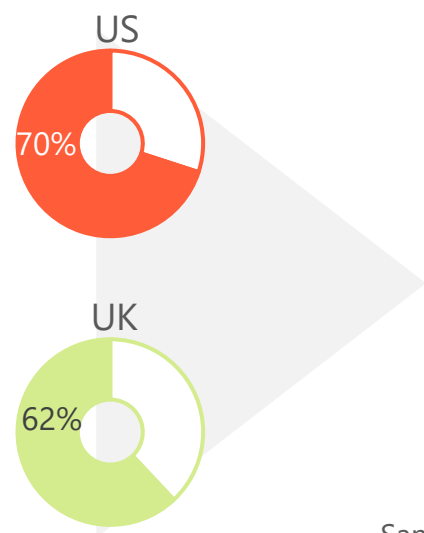


SPEND

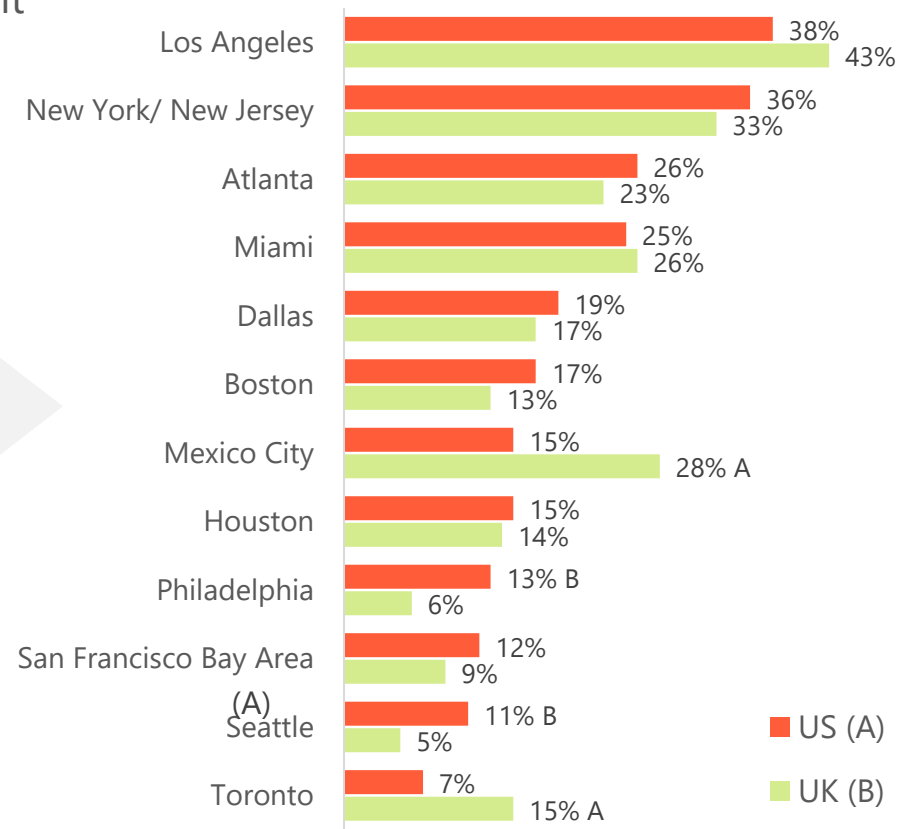


Pop Quiz

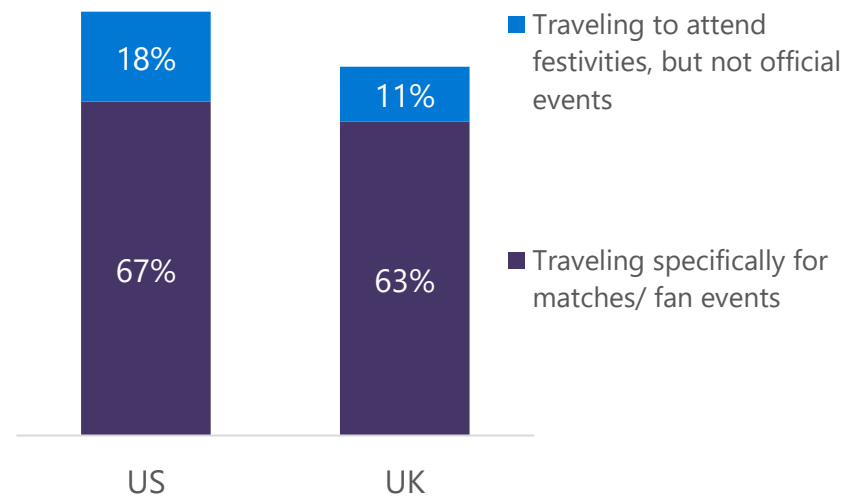
Travel during tournament



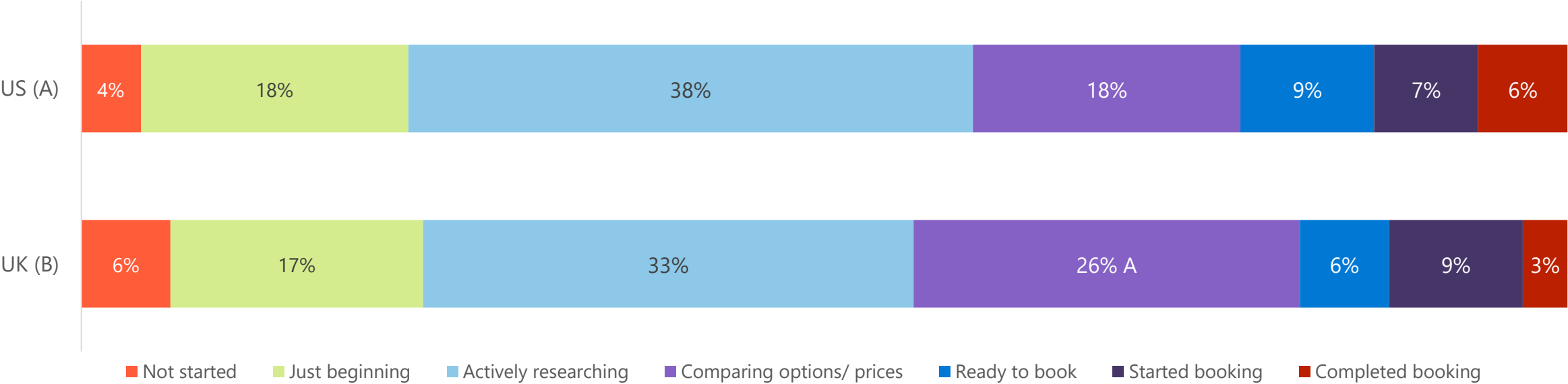
Where do you plan to visit?



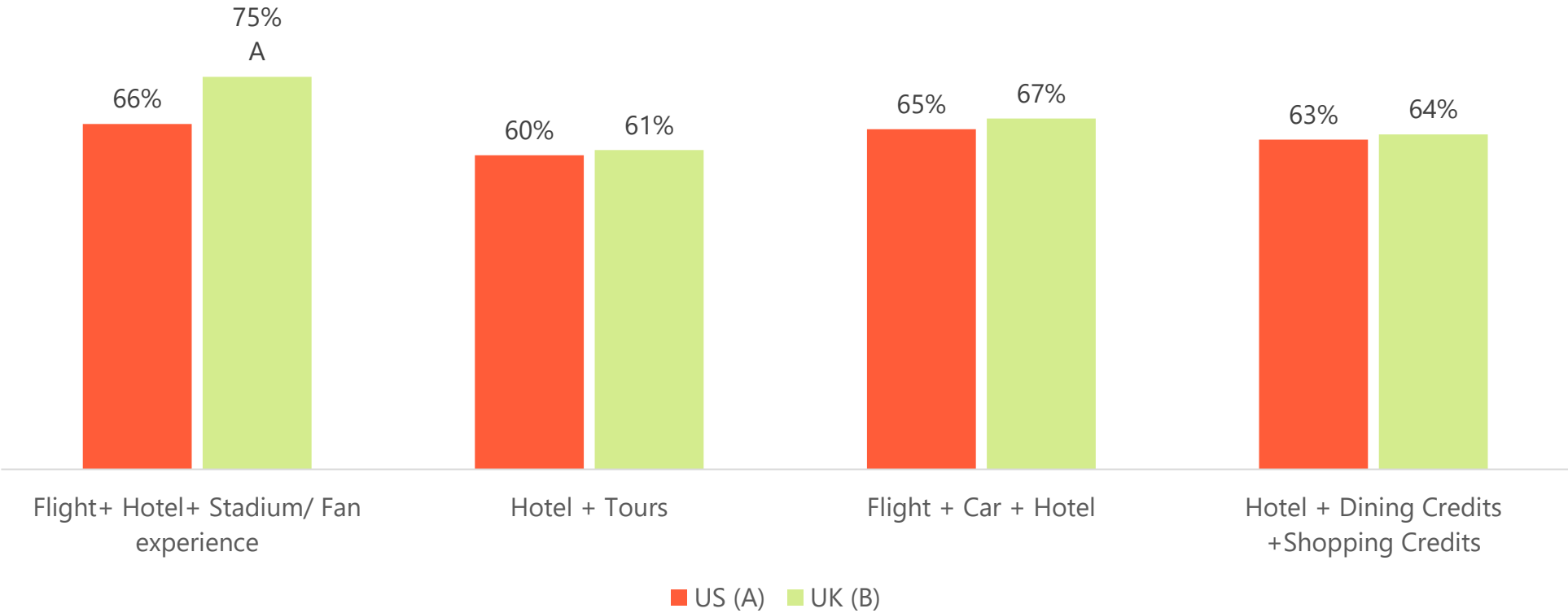
Travel purposes



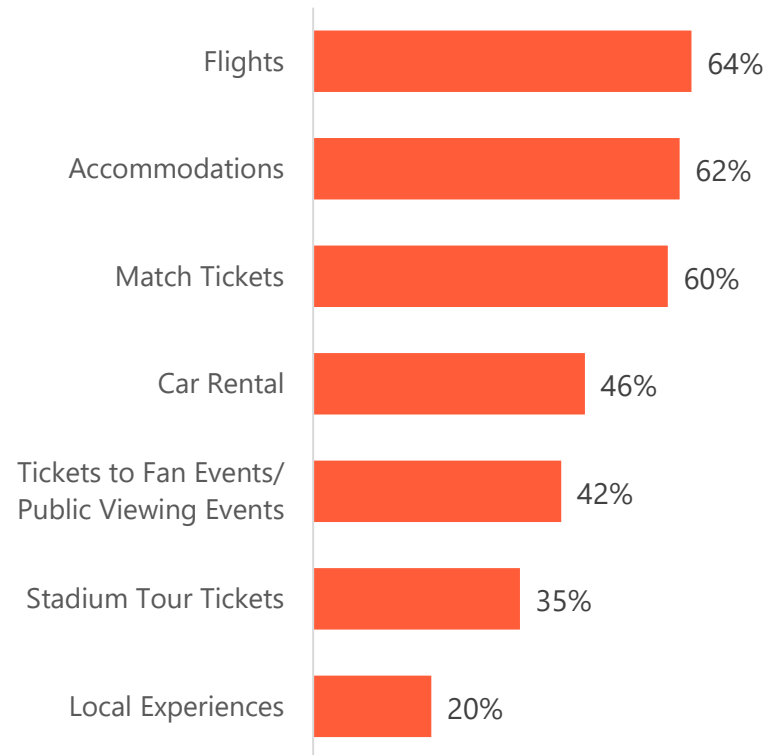
Where are you at in the planning process?



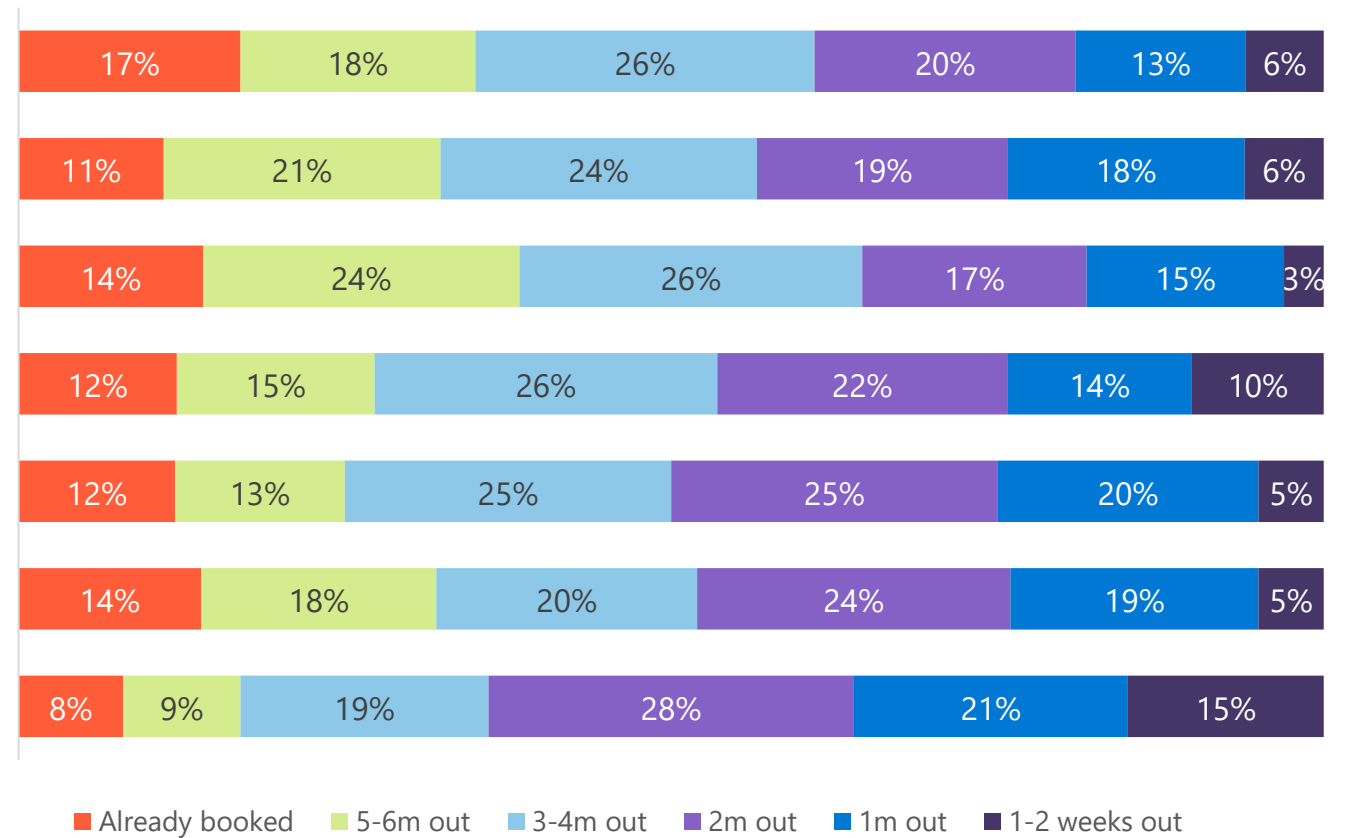
What bundles are you interested in?
Top 2 box (Very/ Extremely Interested)



What will you book?

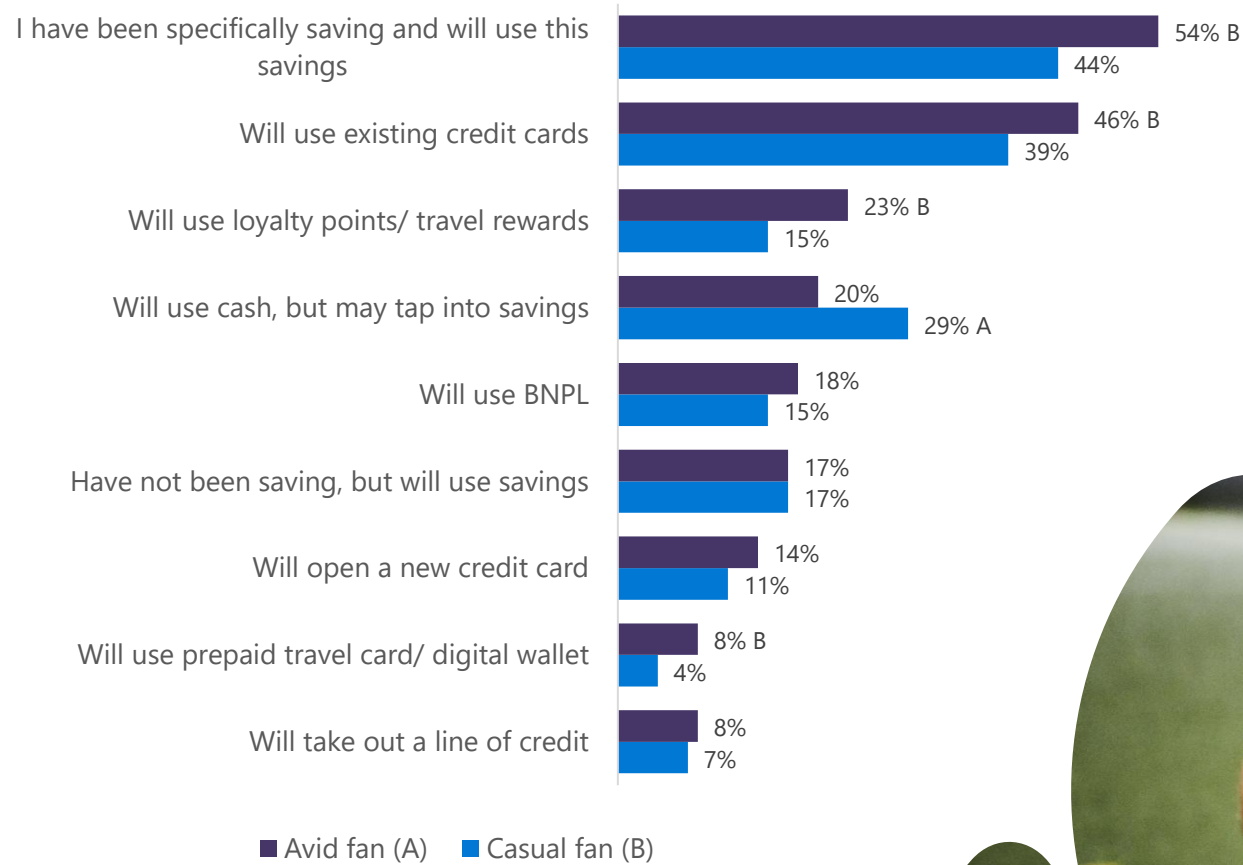


When will you book?



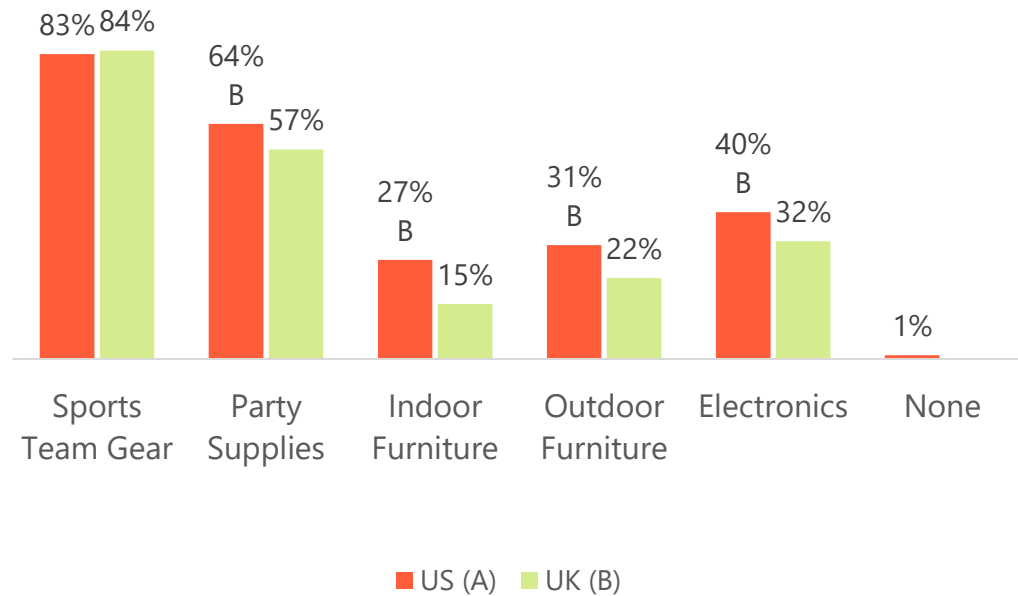
SPEND

How do you plan to pay for expenses?

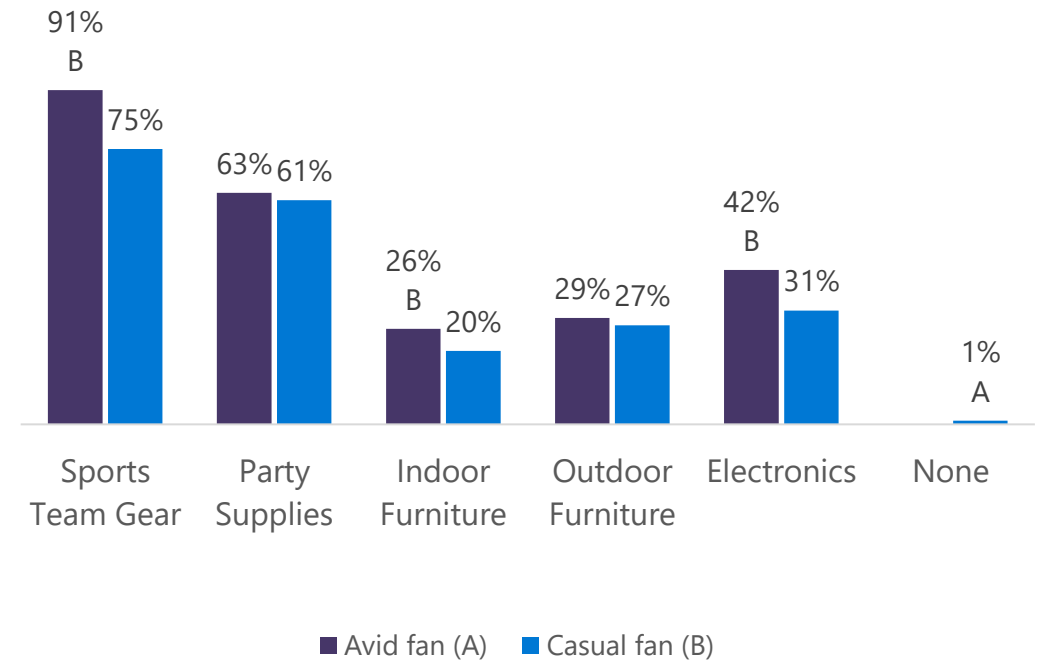


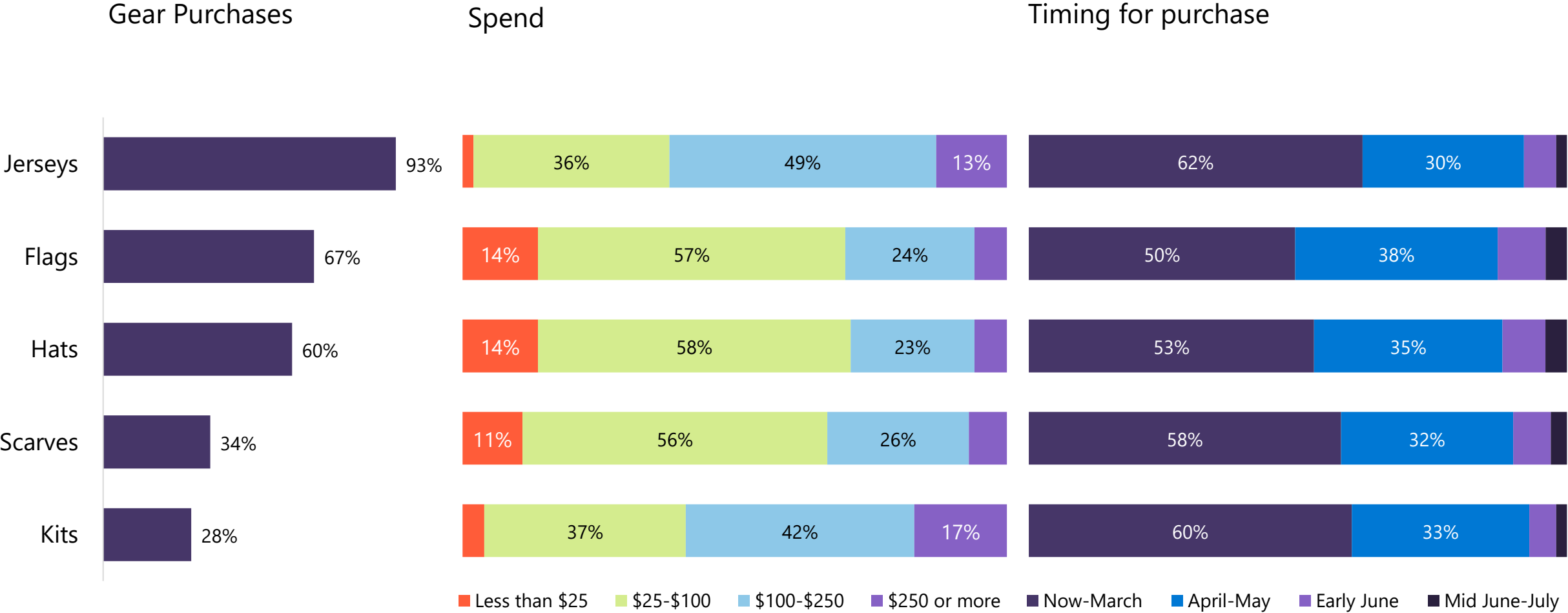
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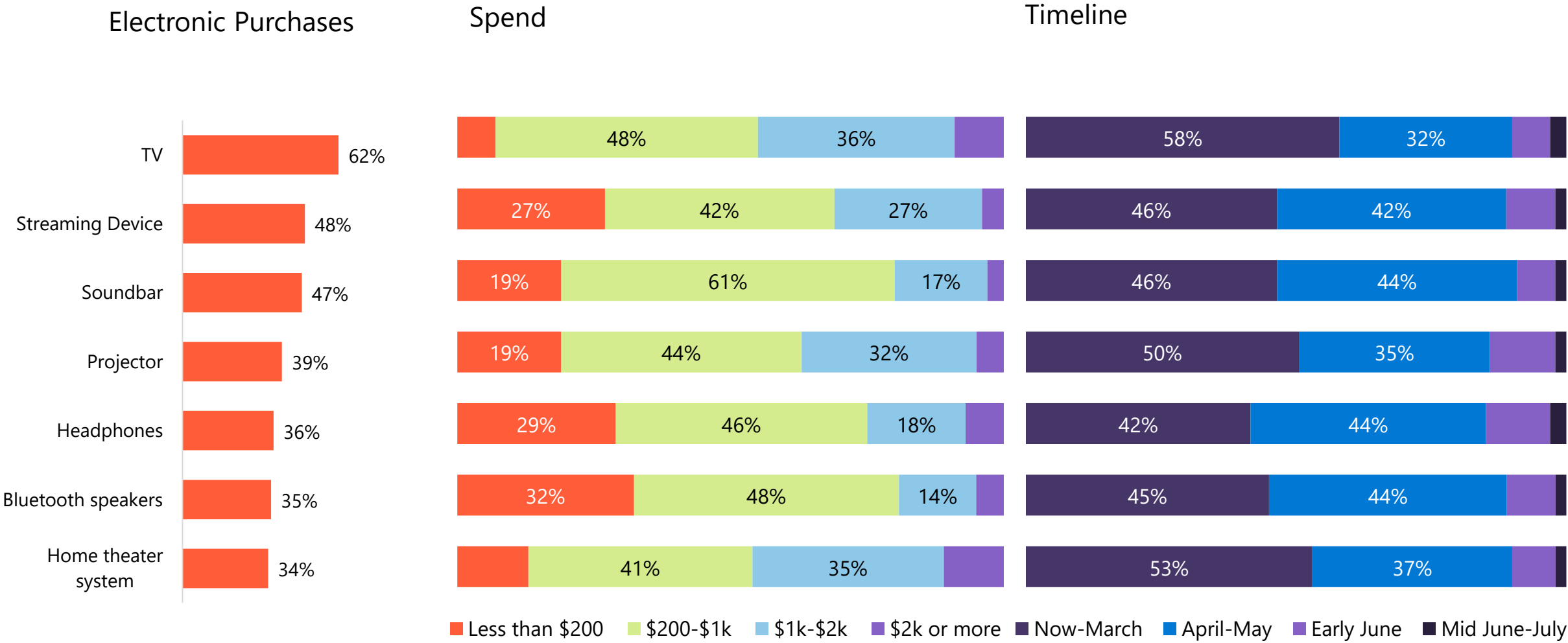
Which of the following do you plan to purchase?



Which of the following do you plan to purchase?







Key takeaways

- 1 Engagement is broad and social, not singular
- 2 Intent is planned and spend is meaningful
- 3 Opportunity peaks before kickoff, not during play

Partner Spotlight

Elyse Werner about WORX



Elyse Werner

Senior Director of Digital Marketing at WORX

Elyse brings over a decade of experience in digital marketing, including six years with WORX. As a strategic digital leader, she specializes in translating complex performance data into clear, high-impact growth strategies. Her background spans global DTC and B2B organizations, with deep expertise in performance media, audience strategy, and cross-platform optimization. Elyse is focused on driving measurable results through disciplined testing, data-informed decision-making, and user-centered thinking.

WORX

WORX is an award-winning branding, digital, and marketing agency powered by a fully integrated, in-house team. We help client partners grow through strategic brand development, increased awareness, and performance-driven lead generation. With business strategists, marketers, brand developers, designers, and technologists working collaboratively under one roof, our structure ensures alignment, efficiency, and stronger ideas that translate into measurable impact.

Measuring success

In an effort to grow lead volume and fighting rising costs and competition in other channels, we turned to Microsoft Ads for more opportunity, with a deliberate account restructuring combined with advanced targeting signals and ongoing strategic optimization.

43%

Increase in lead volume half over half

77%

Decrease in New Customer CPA

420%

Increase in qualified leads YoY

Source: Stats reported by WORX in 2024, 2025

Making AI real: Been there, doing that

James Murray



We've been there making AI real for years



Celebrating 3 years of ads in Copilot

TEXT ADS

What are the top sushi restaurants near me? I'm looking for something authentic

Here are some top sushi restaurants in Austin that offer authentic and delicious experiences:

- 1. Uchi Austin:** Founded by James Beard Award-winning Chef Tyson Cole, Uchi offers non-traditional Japanese cuisine with signature tastings, sushi, and seasonal omakase. It's known for its elevated food and impeccable service.
- 2. Lucky Robot:** This is the first sustainable sushi restaurant in Texas, recognized by the James Beard Foundation's Smart Catch Program. They source their ingredients from local farms and cooperatives, ensuring high environmental and sustainability standards.
- 3. Uchiko Austin:** Originating from the famed Uchi restaurant, Uchiko specializes in upscale sushi, cool tastings, omakase, and small plates in a farmhouse-chic space. It's another creation by Chef Tyson Cole.

These spots should give you a great start on your sushi adventure in Austin! Do any of these sound like what you're looking for?

Microsoft Advertising

If you want to ensure you get a table at your preferred time, you might want to book a table beforehand. Here's a link from Contoso to help you book your place in top Austin sushi restaurants.

Sponsored ...

Book Now on Contoso and Secure Your Spot at Austin's Top Sushi Restaurants.

 Reserve with Contoso on Top Sushi Restaurants
Contoso.com



Message Copilot



FEED-BASED ADS

I'm attending a party next April and the dress code is "elegant early 2000s", what do you think I could dress like?

Alright, let's channel that early 2000s chic. Think of timeless icons like Gwyneth Paltrow and Kate Moss. Here's the vibe:

- **Dresses:** Go for a slip dress with delicate straps or a sleek halter-neck dress. Satin or silk fabrics are perfect for that era's elegance.
- **Shoes:** Strappy heels or delicate sandals to keep it classy and stylish.
- **Accessories:** Small shoulder bags, chokers, and minimalistic jewelry to complement the look. Maybe even a touch of glitter on the eyes for that subtle glam.

You're going to nail it. Ready to strut down memory lane?

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Here are some inspiring picks for an early 2000s party look in spring. Depending on what you're looking for you can go for colorful and airy, or maybe you prefer a two-piece suit that's more formal.

Sponsored ...



Satin Kimono Midi Dress
\$119.97 \$164
Contoso.com



Black and White Midi Dress Angel...
\$87
Fabrikam



Halter Tie Neck Midi Dress in Pleat
\$122.99
Contoso.com



Muse Dropped Hem Mini Dress
\$155.97
Contoso.com



Classic Wo
\$176.50
Fabrikam



Message Copilot



MULTIMEDIA ADS

What vacation rentals would you recommend in Leavenworth?

Leavenworth is such a charming place, like stepping right into Bavaria! Here are a few vacation rentals to consider:

- 1. Icicle Village Resort:** A great spot with a nice balance of comfort and amenities. Perfect for families or couples.
- 2. Sleeping Lady Mountain Resort:** If you're into eco-friendly stays and a more rustic vibe, this place has cozy cabins and beautiful scenery.
- 3. Pine River Ranch:** Offers a more romantic and secluded setting, ideal for couples looking for a quiet getaway.
- 4. Haus Hanika:** Right on the river and only a short walk to downtown. It has that authentic Bavarian feel.

Each of these places has its own charm and appeal, depending on what kind of experience you're after. How does that sound?

Microsoft Advertising

Contoso.com may be worth considering: with its unique rentals, easy booking, and verified reviews, you're sure to find the perfect stay in the charming Bavarian village of Leavenworth. Discover your ideal getaway today.



Sponsored ...

Book your Hotel in Leavenworth WA online with no reservation costs. Benefit from great rates.

 Leavenworth Vacation Rentals | Book with Contoso
<https://www.contoso.com>

Book Now



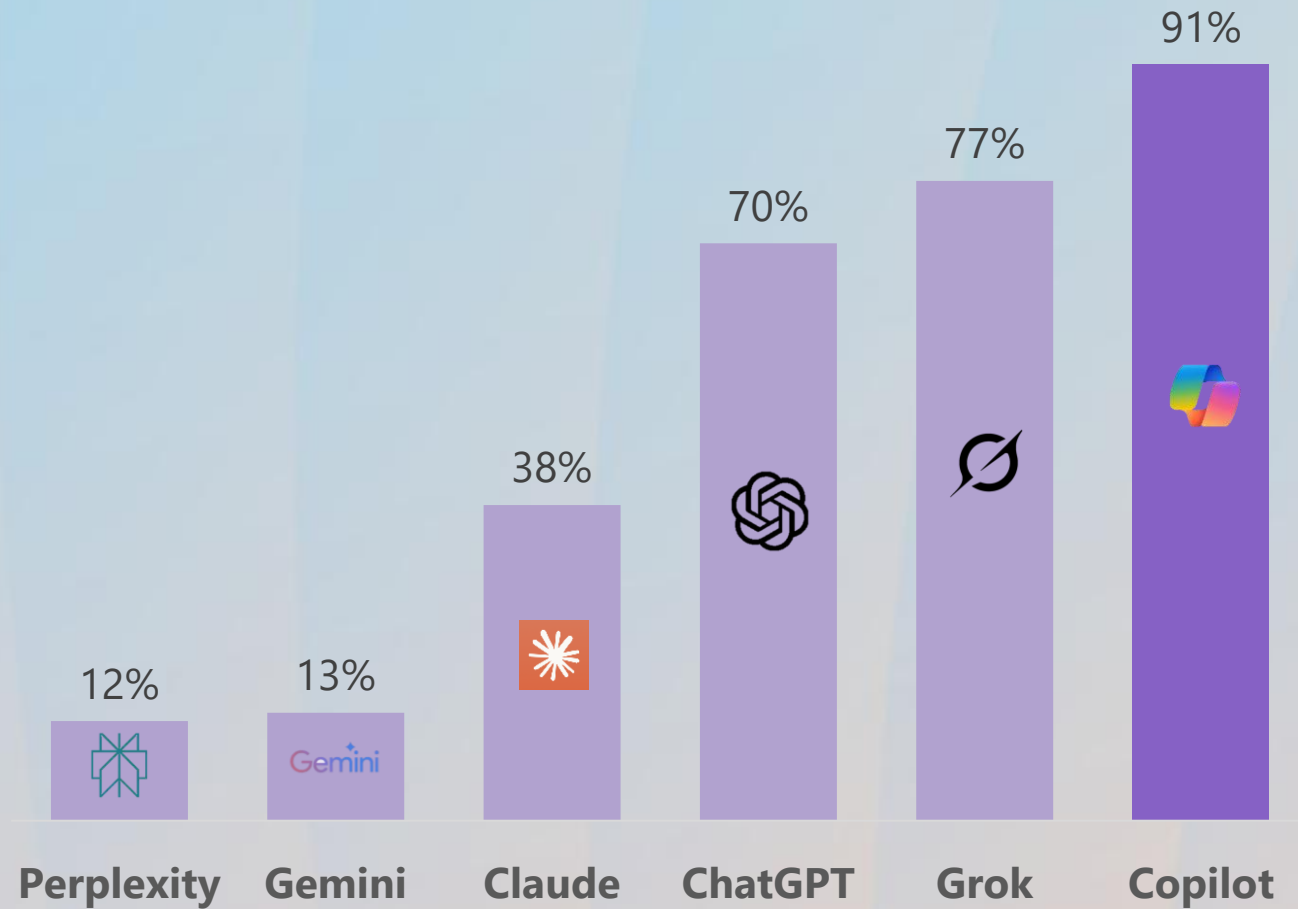
Message Copilot



Copilot weekly mobile usage continues to grow faster than competitors

+91% increase in Copilot weekly app sessions since January 2025

% Increase in Weekly App Session Count (January 2025 vs. August 2025)



We've been there since
the beginning, what are
we doing now?

The web was built for clicking. AI is built for acting.

Past

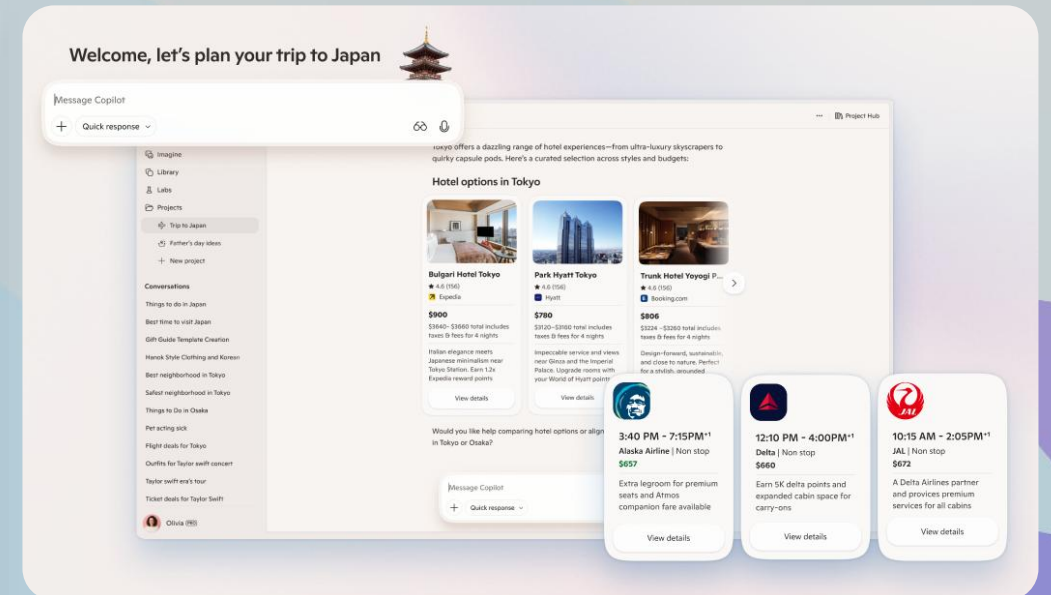
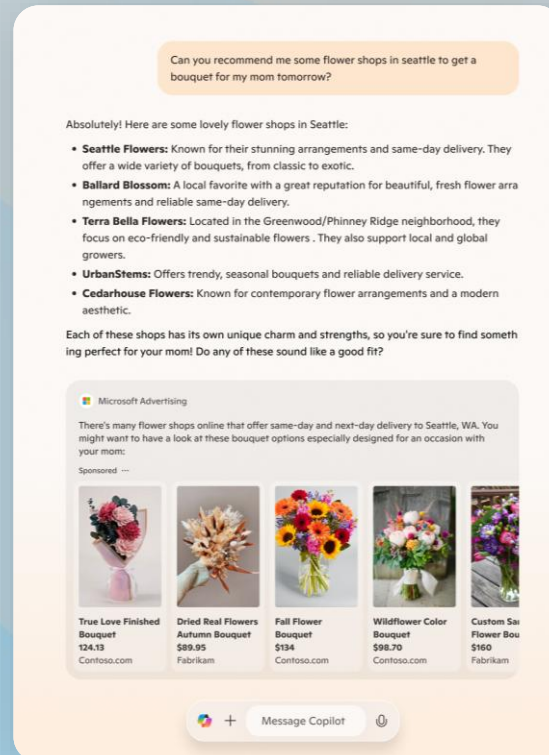
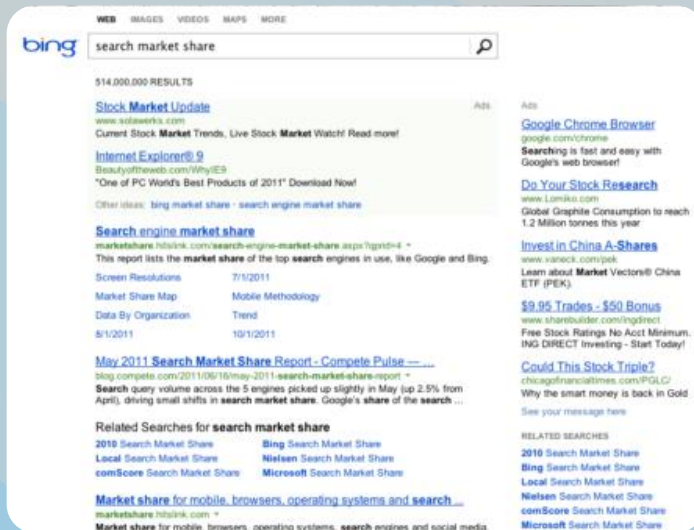
Pages, feeds, links

Present

Answers, conversations, Copilots

Next

Decisions, execution, outcomes



Doing that: making AI real today

Be chosen

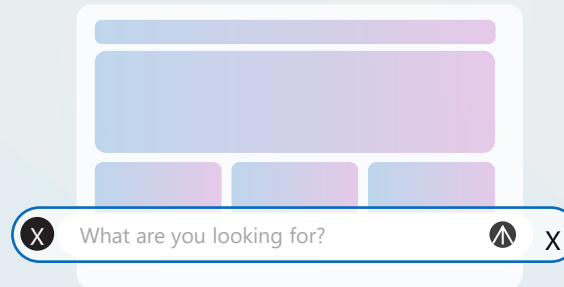
Make brands and publishers visible, trusted, and citable inside AI answers



AEO & GEO

Participate

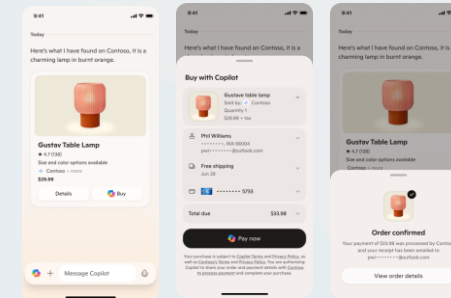
Let brands participate directly in AI-led decisions, not just drive traffic



Brand Agents

Convert

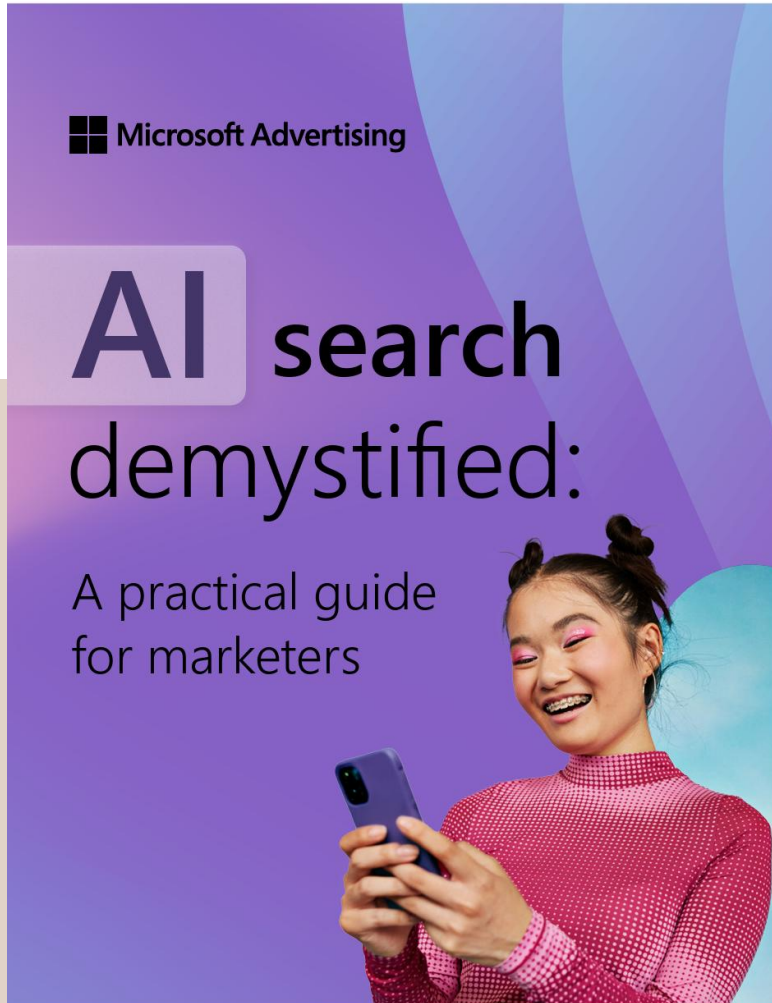
Turn high-intent moments into outcomes, without breaking trust



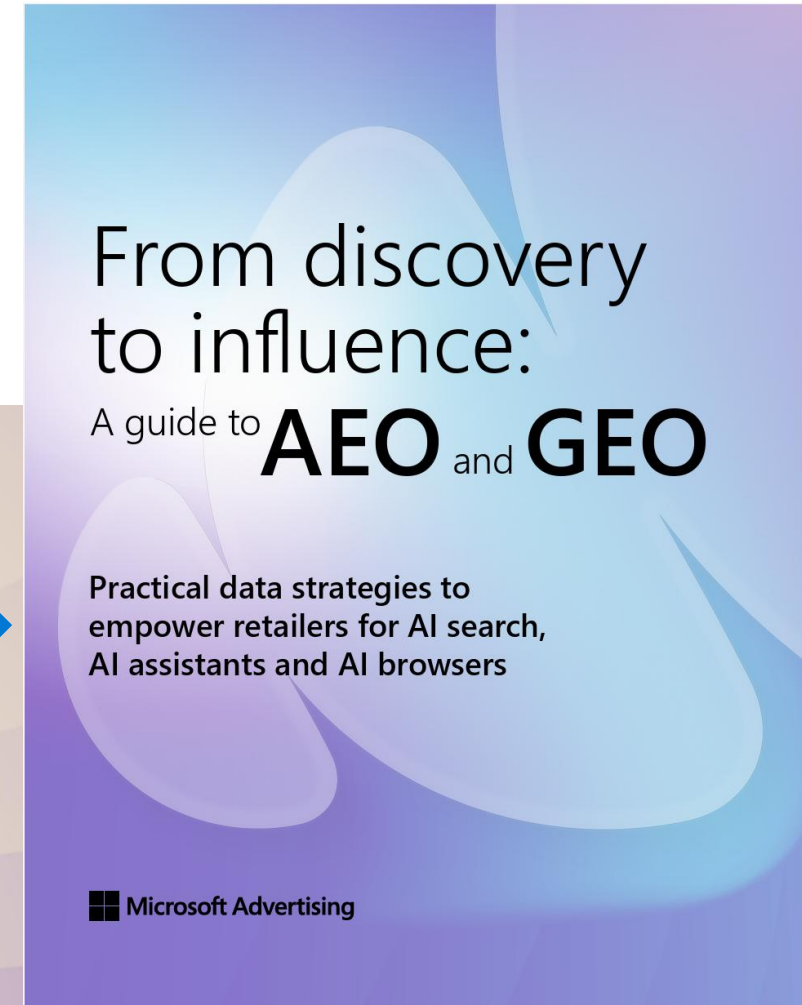
Copilot Checkout

Two new whitepapers to help you navigate AI search

Use this as your go-to for what to do with Copilot and AI search.



Use this as a deep dive to understand how to optimize for organic results in AEO and GEO.



New AI marketers guide available now

More practical tips for marketers

AI SEARCH DEMYSTIFIED: A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR MARKETERS

How to write clear, structured content for visibility in AI search

Clear, well-structured content that's easily readable for web crawlers isn't a new tactic for success. However, in the world of GEO, clarity goes beyond just word choice and into how you phrase, format, and punctuate so AI systems can interpret your content with confidence.

AI systems don't just scan for keywords. They look for clear meaning, consistent context, and clean formatting. Precise, structured language makes it easier for AI to classify your content as relevant and lift it into answers.

How can semantic clarity boost your AI search rankings?

- Write for intent, not just keywords**
Use phrasing that directly answers the questions users ask.
- Avoid vague language**
Terms like innovative or eco mean little without specifics. Instead, anchor claims in measurable facts.
- Add context**
A product page should say '42 dBA dishwasher designed for open-concept kitchens' instead of just 'quiet dishwasher'.
- Use synonyms and related terms**
This reinforces meaning and helps AI connect concepts (e.g., quiet, noise level, sound rating).

What formatting and punctuation practices help AI parse content?

- Keep punctuation simple**
Use periods and commas consistently; avoid decorative arrows, symbols, or long strings of punctuation that break parsing.
- Be cautious with em dashes**
Overuse can confuse sentence structure for machines. A period or semicolon is usually clearer.
- Use bullets or numbers for lists**
Structured formatting signals clear separation of ideas, which AI can repurpose directly. However, avoid overusing them. Bullets work best for key steps, comparisons, or highlights.

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Industry expert contributions

AI SEARCH DEMYSTIFIED: A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR MARKETERS

Moving from SEO to GEO: How do brands show up?

While the specific goals of every business or publisher differ, AI search is making one thing clear: The most valuable signals are the ones connected to visibility.

According to McKinsey, half of consumers are already using AI-powered search today, and it stands to impact

\$750 billion in revenue by 2028.¹

Being visible matters to your bottom line. By tracking impressions, placement in AI answers, and citations, brands can see where content is being surfaced, trusted, and considered—even before a visit occurs.

But impressions, citations, and links to trusted sources sounds like traditional SEO. One of the key questions is whether GEO is the same as SEO or if it's a completely new discipline. The answer is nuanced, but both are actually true.

It would be wrong though to assume that to thrive in the world of GEO as a marketer, you just need to continue with your existing SEO strategy. The experience of AI-driven search is very different from a box and blue links that have been the mainstay of traditional search for the last three decades. Search has changed. As such, the content that you need to consider in order to be visible for GEO also has to adapt."

Lily Ray
Vice President, SEO Strategy and Research, Amsive

¹McKinsey & Company, New front door to the internet: Winning in the age of AI search, McKinsey Growth, Marketing & Sales Insights, <https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/growth-marketing-and-sales/our-insights/new-front-door-to-the-internet-winning-in-the-age-of-ai-search>

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Linked to latest product releases

AI SEARCH DEMYSTIFIED: A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR MARKETERS

Brand agents

Once your brand has been discovered, guiding a consumer through the research phase of your product's capabilities becomes ever more important. Brand Agents were [officially launched in January 2026](#), offering a turnkey AI shopping agent that can assist your customer through the purchase journey.

Natural conversation
Customers can ask questions naturally, like:
"I'm looking for a gift for my mom."

The agent responds in your brand's voice and guides them through options.

Product comparison and guidance
It can compare products, answer questions about shipping or returns, and recommend the best fit—making decisions easier. With access to purchase history, they can also assist with post-purchase scenarios such as suggesting complementary products for previous purchases.

Checkout assistance
When customers are ready, the agent helps complete the purchase by providing checkout links and answering last-minute questions.

Upselling and cross-selling
The agent suggests complementary products with prompts like:
"You might also like..."

to help customers discover more options that fit their needs.

Copilot Checkout

Copilot's shopping experiences are designed to turn shopper inspiration into action—no new tabs or jumping across unfamiliar sites. It's all there in one place. When purchase intent is detected, Copilot surfaces instant checkout for the user to complete their purchase.

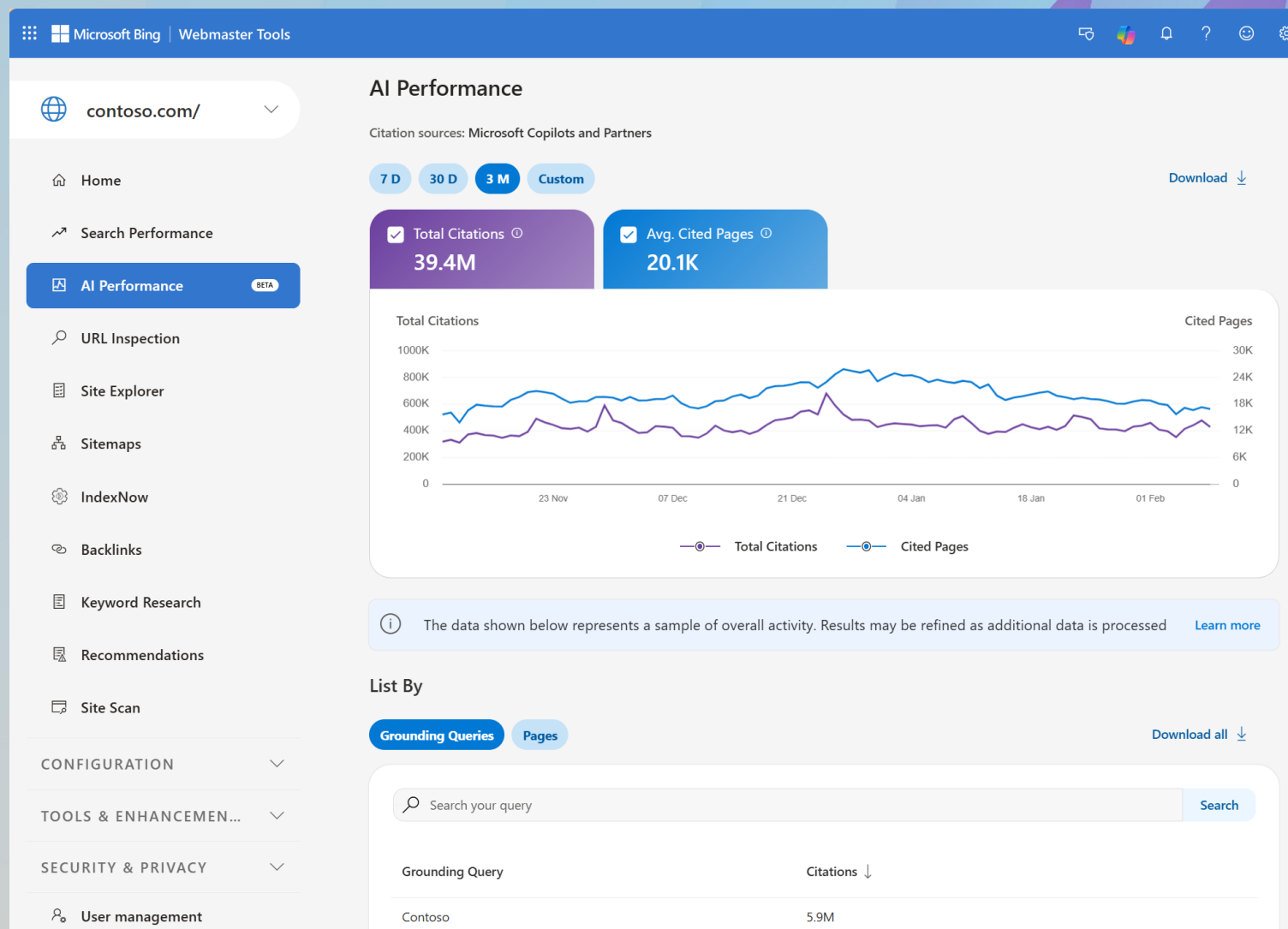
[Copilot Checkout](#) offers merchants scale without added complexity. With a single integration, retailers become instant checkout merchants in Copilot and will automatically extend to future Microsoft properties such as Bing, MSN, and Edge as they roll out—no extra setup or added tech needed.

Currently available in the US, shoppers can purchase from leading retail brands like Urban Outfitters, Anthropologie, Free People, and Reebok, and discover unique, handcrafted items from Etsy sellers—with many more joining soon. Behind the scenes, Microsoft is adopting open standards like the Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP) for seamless merchant onboarding, making it easier for merchants to onboard and scale.

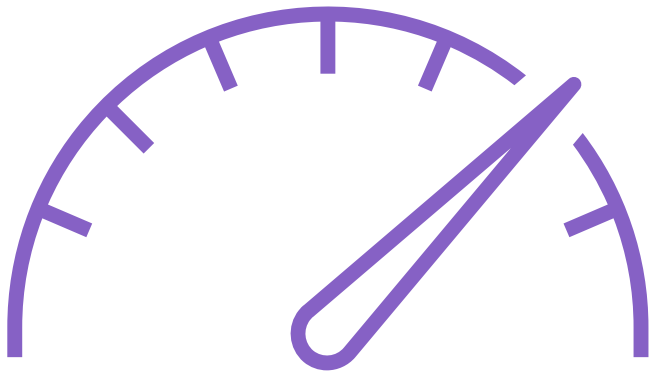
To find out more about Brand Agents and join our waiting list, check out the [Microsoft Clarity website](#).

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Announcing AI performance in Bing Webmaster tools public preview



What's measured in the new AI dashboard?



01

Total Citations: Shows the total number of citations that are displayed as sources in AI-generated answers during the selected time frame.

02

Average Cited Pages: Shows the average number of unique pages from your site that are displayed as sources in AI-generated answers.

03

Grounding queries: Shows the key phrases the AI used when retrieving content that was referenced in AI-generated answers.

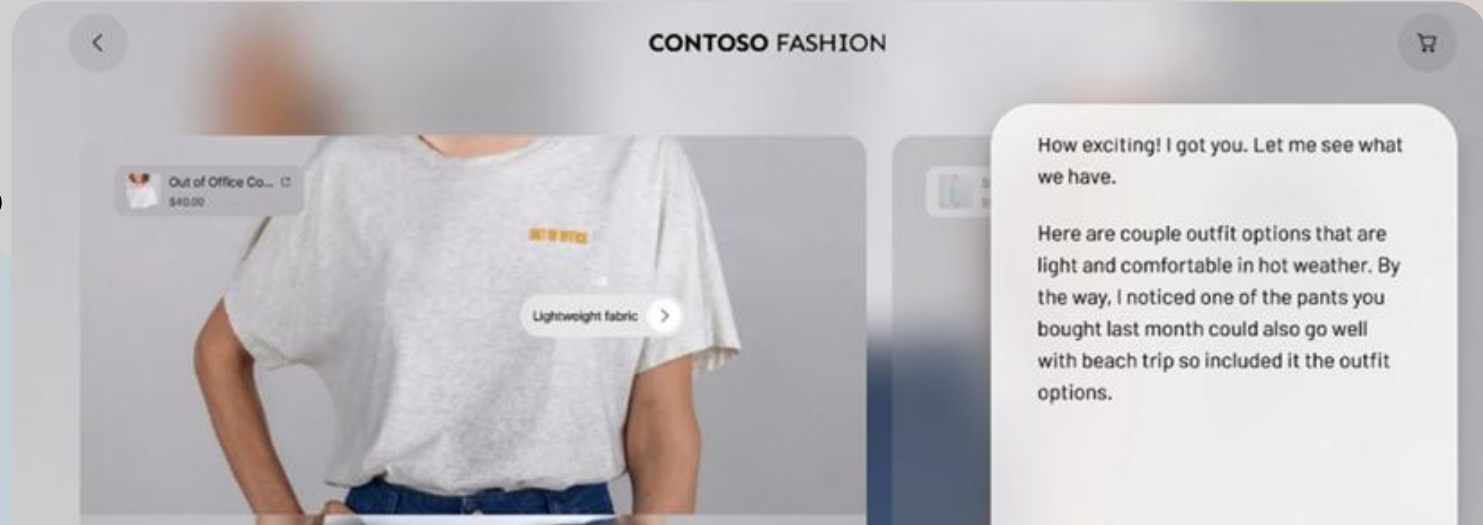
04

Page-level citation activity: Shows citation counts for specific URLs from your site, to see which pages are most often referenced across AI-generated answers

05

Visibility trends over time: The timeline shows how citation activity for your site changes over time, making it easier to spot trends.

Brand Agents



Key benefits to customers



Natural conversations

Customers can ask questions naturally, like *"I'm looking for a gift for my mom."* The agent responds in your brand's voice and guides them through options.



Product comparison and guidance

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Checkout assistance

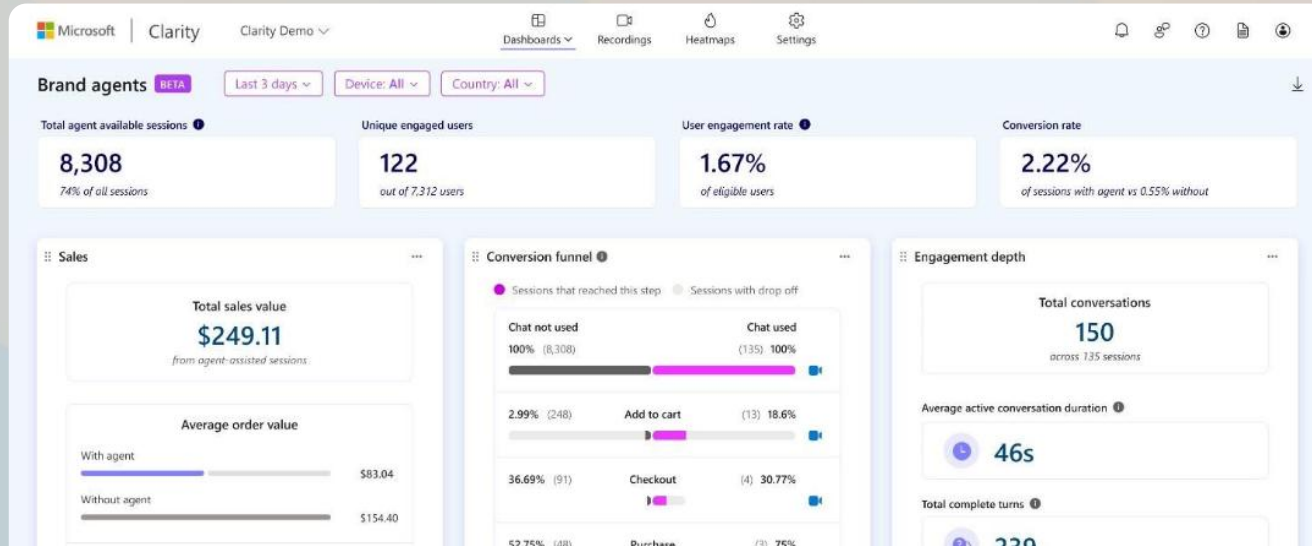
When customers are ready, the agent helps complete the purchase by providing checkout links and answering last-minute questions.



Upselling and cross-selling

The agent suggests complementary products with prompts like *"You might also like..."* to help customers discover more options that fit their needs.

Brand Agents



Key benefits to brands



Faster setup

Go live in days, not quarters. No heavy IT lift needed and no overhead cost or additional investment to use AI.



Enterprise trust

Built on Microsoft's secure cloud with privacy and compliance at the core.



Actionable insights

Microsoft Clarity tracks engagement and conversion uplift, all surfaced in a dashboard that helps optimize strategy.



Smarter with every session

Persistent context and learning deliver ever-smarter recommendations and proactive guidance, unlike static chatbots.



Trained on your brand

Trained on your full product catalog, brand voice, and unique selling points. Every conversation is distinctively yours, never generic.

Pop Quiz

3X

Higher conversion rates
in brand agent assisted
sessions compared to
unassisted sessions

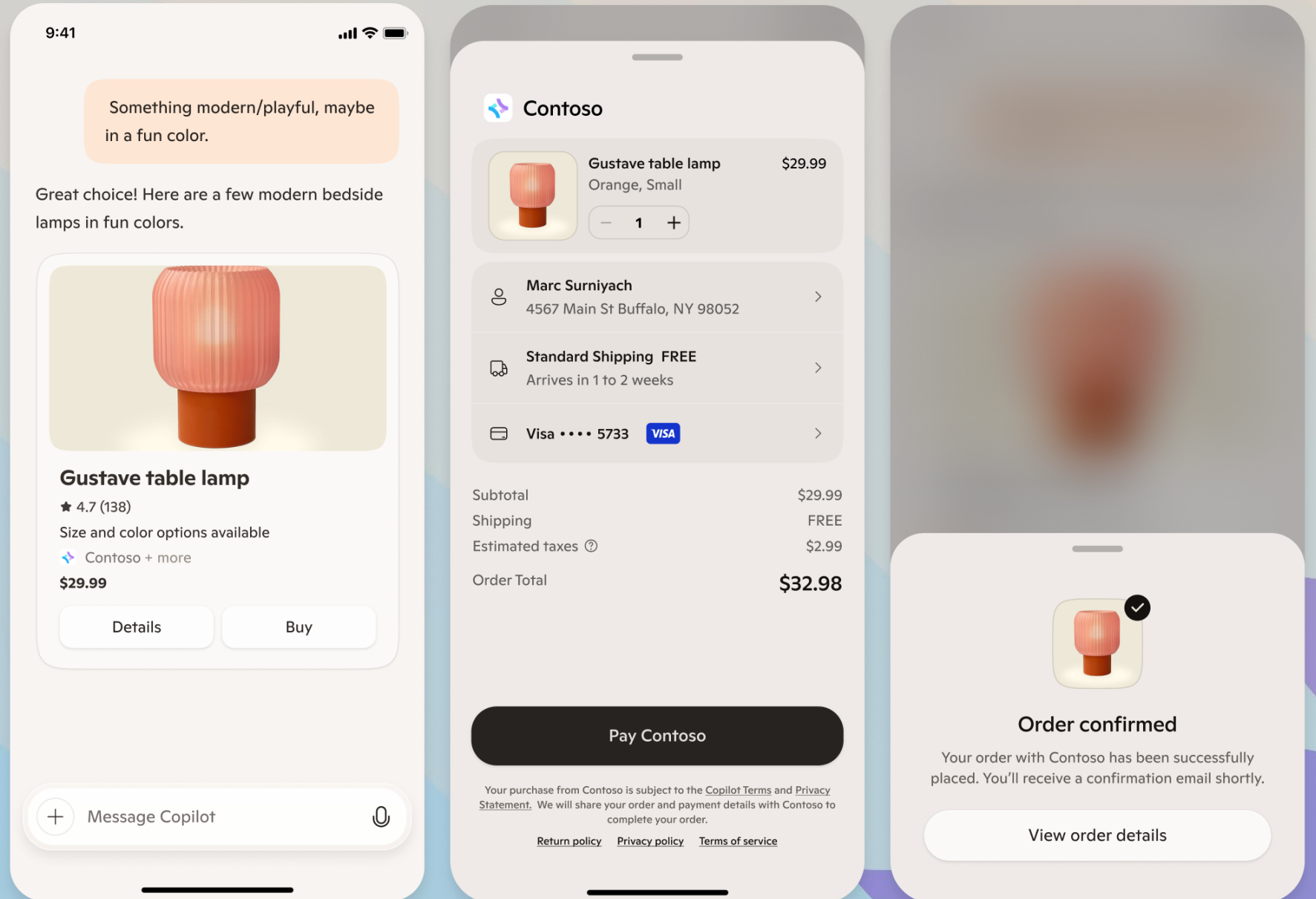
Source: Alexander Del Rossa internal data, over a 30-day period, November 2025



Introducing

Copilot Checkout Conversations that convert

Turn inspiration into action. Frictionless flows with no redirects - checkout where customers are deciding.



Built on trusted commerce infrastructure



We meet you where you are - adopting industry protocols such as ACP and integrating with existing infrastructure for secure transactions at scale.

Merchant-forward by design

Merchants remain the merchant of record, owning the transaction data and customer relationships. Built to enable, not replace.



“

One of the biggest advantages for our sellers is simplicity—onboard once and automatically be supported across Copilot surfaces.

Rafe Colburn

Chief Product and Technology Officer

Etsy



Thank you!





Partner Workshop

Troy Scoffield

Microsoft Advertising Partner Workshop

Wednesday March 4, 2026

8:00 am PT | 11:00 am ET | 5:00 pm CET

Join us to learn how to turn everyday marketing deliverables into real time savings and productivity gains through proven Copilot use cases.

Limited capacity so register soon!



Learn how to use Copilot for common workflows.



Follow along and apply Copilot in real time.



Develop confidence to utilize Copilot for your workflows.

Q&A

Sub-divider style

Thank you